

Sensory-Friendly Meal Planner & Grocery Guide

TEACCH-inspired visuals • Full-color printable • Family-centered & clinician-friendly



Stress-free weekly layouts
Plan meals the whole family can enjoy.



Visual grocery list
Categorized, fast, predictable shopping.



Sensory profile templates
Track textures, temperatures, flavors, colors.



Food-chaining maps
Expand accepted foods step-by-step.

This planner is educational and not a substitute for medical care. If you suspect ARFID or growth/nutrition concerns, consult a qualified clinician.

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Quick Start: How to use this planner

- Complete the Sensory Profile first (textures, temperatures, flavors, colors).
- Use the Routine & Environment page to reduce sensory overload (noise, lights, seating, timing).
- Plan your week on the Weekly Meal Plan: include safe foods + one “learn-about” food using food chaining.
- Print the Visual Grocery List and Store Route for calmer, faster trips.
- Track pantry & budget so your plan is realistic and repeatable.

Evidence-based anchors (overview)

- Visual supports & predictability reduce anxiety and improve independence for autistic learners (e.g., visual schedules; evidence across settings).
- Low-pressure exposures and systematic desensitization/food exposure improve acceptance over time.
- Food chaining expands diet by moving from accepted foods to similar targets (texture/temperature/taste/color).
- Division of Responsibility: adults decide what/when/where; children decide whether/how much.

Sensory Profile: Food & Environment

Dimension	Like	Tolerate	Avoid	Notes
Texture (crunchy, smooth, mixed, stringy, chewy, etc.)				
Temperature (cold, room temp, warm, hot)				
Flavor (sweet, savory, bitter, sour, spicy)				
Color/Appearance (beige-only, colorful, sauce/no sauce)				
Smell (strong, mild, specific aromas)				
Utensils/Plates (non-slip, straw, open cup, spoon preference)				

Trigger Tracker (check if present)

- Bright lights

Cold aisles (freezer)
- Loud music/announcements

Unfamiliar utensils
- Crowds/lines

Food mixing/touching
- Strong smells

Time pressure

Routine & Environment Planner

Daily schedule (meals/snacks)	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Breakfast							
Snack							
Lunch							
Snack							
Dinner							

Noise plan	Use ear defenders	No TV	Low voices	White noise
Lighting plan	Dimmer	Warm bulbs	Avoid flicker	
Seating & posture	Feet supported	Stable chair	Non-slip plate	Straw/open-cup
Expectations & roles	Adult decides <i>what/when/where</i>; child decides <i>whether/how much</i>			

Weekly Meal Plan — Page 1

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Snacks	Safe foods on hand	Try-new/learn-about	Notes
Mon							
Tue							
Wed							
Thu							
Fri							
Sat							
Sun							

Exposure tally (circle as you offer without pressure): 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10+

Weekly Meal Plan — Page 2

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Snacks	Safe foods on hand	Try-new/learn-about	Notes
Mon							
Tue							
Wed							
Thu							
Fri							
Sat							
Sun							

Exposure tally (circle as you offer without pressure): 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10+

Food Chaining Map (Template)

Accepted food	Small change #1	Small change #2	Small change #3	Target food

Example chains (copy these and adapt):

Chicken nuggets	Breaded fish sticks	Baked fish sticks	Baked fish (light seasoning)	Grilled fish
White pasta	Mix 75/25 white/whole-grain	50/50 mix	25/75 mix	Whole-grain pasta
French fries	Baked fries	Baked sweet-potato fries	Roasted carrots sticks	Steamed carrots

Visual Grocery List (Icons + Checkboxes)

	Produce	Apples Bananas Berries Carrots Cucumbers Lettuce Tomatoes Potatoes
	Protein	Chicken Beef Turkey Eggs Tofu/Tempeh Beans/Lentils Fish Deli (low-noise time)
	Dairy/Calcium	Milk Yogurt Cheese Cottage cheese Fortified alt-milk Greek yogurt String cheese Pudding
	Grains	Bread Whole-grain bread Tortillas Rice Pasta Oats Crackers Cereal (low sugar)
	Pantry	Oil Sauce (plain) Broth Spices (mild) Peanut/seed butter Applesauce Canned fruit Canned veg
	Freezer	Frozen fruit Frozen veg Fish sticks Chicken tenders Waffles Peas Corn Mixed veg

Store Map & Shopping Route

Entrance	Produce	Bakery	Deli	Aisles	Frozen	Dairy	Checkout
Stop #	1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Tip: Choose quieter hours; bring a sensory kit (headphones, chew, fidget); keep list in aisle order.

Pantry / Fridge / Freezer Inventory

Location	Item	Qty	Use by	Notes
Pantry				
Pantry				
Fridge				
Fridge				
Freezer				
Freezer				

Budget & Cost Tracker

Week	Planned (\$)	Actual (\$)	Variance	Notes
W1				
W2				
W3				
W4				

Emergency Safe Foods & Backup Plan

Always-stock items (safe foods)	Quantity to keep	Reorder at	Notes
Calm-down plan for overwhelm (choose 2 – 3 tools)	Who helps?	Where?	Notes
Noise (headphones, quiet car time)			
Break (outside, car, quiet corner)			

Notes

References (Evidence Snapshot)

- Visual supports and schedules are evidence-based for autistic learners across settings (see NCAEP / systematic reviews).
- Systematic desensitization and food exposure approaches improve acceptance in autism-related food selectivity.
- Food Chaining is a structured, incremental method that builds from accepted to target foods sharing similar properties.
- Division of Responsibility (adult: what/when/where; child: whether/how much) is widely implemented in pediatric feeding.
- ARFID red flags: significant weight/growth impact, nutritional deficiency, supplement/tube dependence, psychosocial interference—seek professional evaluation.

This resource is educational and not clinical advice. Work with your pediatrician, registered dietitian, OT/SLP, or psychologist when needed.